



Discussion Guide: Jonathan Merritt

The Death and Resurrection of Sacred Speech

Reflect

- Jonathan quotes the Apostle Paul: "We believe, and so we speak" (2 Cor 4:13). He explains that the best way to understand what Paul means by belief is "belove." What is it about the nature of belief as love that fuels the ability to have spiritual/religious conversations?
- How is our human ability to communicate fundamental to how we are made in God's image? What creative power does Jonathan attribute to our identity as "speech-creatures?"
- What are some "sacred words" that you feel have either lost their meaning or have been distorted? What are the important or beautiful aspects of these words that you would love to see redeemed? What would it take to do so?

Respond

- What words have been spoken to you that made a drastic impact on your life (good or bad)? Conversely, what words have you spoken to someone else that made a drastic impact on their life (good or bad)?
- What fears prevent you from "speaking God"? How can faith communities help foster the development of courage to speak about God in ways that are authentic, honest, and relevant?
- Francis of Assisi is often credited with having said, "Preach the Gospel at all times. When necessary, use words." What would you affirm about this statement? What are its potential drawbacks? How has Jonathan's talked changed your understanding of this saying?